

Moses Yang

小馬

It was love at first sight,
or so they say. But really,
it's impossible to know
whether you chose me
or I chose you
or we chose each other
or you were just
the cheapest Webkinz at Walmart.

They say they made you gallop in front of my carriage,
and peeped a small smile peeking out from under the tight covers.
I must've been too young to snap the shutters shut,
but maybe I wasn't
and maybe you were just
a passing gift
from one of my mother's students
or a hand-me-down
from one of my father's coworkers.
It was all the same to me.

You and me —
We would travel the world
riding into the sunset together
in the backseat of the family car.
We would play at the beach under the summer haze,
building a sandcastle just for us:
a knight in shining armor and his trusty stallion.
We would visit Taiwan's alleys during the night
— I clutched you so tight —
me feeding you baozi while you fed me company.

And when you made a mess of yourself
swimming at the ocean and eating too eagerly,
I would chide you for being so irresponsible.
Both of us knew that you would get thrown to the savages,
struggling to keep your neck upright in a whirlpool of muck,
then blasted to oblivion by the fiery roar of a sleepless dragon.

I would
wait
pudgy hands pressed
against the looming window
— of that darndest machine —
eyes turned down and forehead creased,
enough tears to play in the sea one more time.
I would wait for you to come back from your quest to snatch the golden fleece,
hoping you would be healed from your hurt.
Only to find
holes deepening along your seams
and yet another
crack
in your eyes
— catching the light almost
as if to promise that it would be okay.

There comes a time where a knight outgrows his horse.
I became too big for you to carry my burdens
and too ambitious for you to carry my dreams.
I ran to another land and
left you
to keep my stable stable.

But when I falter
on foreign words
and stumble into
uncomfortable comforts,
I remember how you taught me
to always charge galliantly into battle
fearful or not.
I remember how you would always
put one step before the other
and lift your chin high
no matter the cost
just to catch up to me
for one more warm embrace.